

Cold Harbor, June 1864

Selected primary source pages from *The War of the Rebellion: A Compilation of the Official Records of the Union and Confederate Armies*, Series I, Volume XXXVI, compiled to accompany "The Seven-Minute Myth at Cold Harbor," *Echo & Chronicle*.

Contents

Grant to Halleck, June 3, 1864, 2 p.m. (Part 3, p. 524)

Grant's dispatch reporting the June 3 assault, including the line — "Our loss was not severe, nor do I suppose the enemy to have lost heavily."

Hancock, Meade, and Grant exchange, June 3 morning (Part 3, p. 525)

Hancock's 6 a.m. report from the front, Meade's order to press the attack, and Meade's 7 a.m. message asking Grant whether to continue.

Grant's 7 a.m. reply and the 12:30 p.m. suspension order (Part 3, p. 526)

Grant's instruction to suspend any assault that cannot succeed, and the order at 12:30 p.m. calling off the attack.

Grant to Lee, June 5, 1864 (Part 3, p. 600)

Grant's first letter proposing an informal, standing arrangement to recover the dead and wounded, and Lee's reply proposing the customary flag of truce instead.

Hancock to army headquarters, June 5, 1864, 1 p.m. (Part 3, p. 603)

Hancock's request: "Can any arrangement be made by which the wounded in front of Barlow can be removed? I understand men wounded on the 3d are still lying there."

Meade to Grant, and Grant's reply, June 5, 1864 (Part 3, p. 604)

Meade forwards Hancock's request; Grant authorizes sending a flag proposing a suspension of firing where the wounded lay.

Grant and Lee, June 6, 1864 (Part 3, p. 638)

Grant proposes a two-hour suspension of hostilities to collect the wounded; Lee's reply clarifying the flag-of-truce procedure.

Lee to Grant, June 6, 1864, 7 p.m. (Part 3, p. 639)

Lee proposes an 8–10 p.m. window that evening for both sides to recover their wounded.

Note in Letter Book, and Grant to Lee, June 7, 1864, 10:30 a.m. (Part 3, p. 666)

The editorial note explaining that Lee's confirmation of the June 6 window did not reach the front lines until after it had closed, so nothing was collected; a Confederate burial party sent out regardless was captured. Grant's letter to Lee recounting the failure.

Lee to Grant, and Grant's final reply, June 7, 1864 (Part 3, p. 667)

Lee proposes a new 6–8 p.m. window; Grant accepts. The truce that finally reached the troops, four days after the assault.

Source: United States War Department, *The War of the Rebellion: A Compilation of the Official Records of the Union and Confederate Armies*, Series I, Volume XXXVI, Part 3 (Washington: Government Printing Office, 1891). Public domain.

people are permitted to come here they will be provided for, and I send a steamer for the purpose of bringing all who desire to come. Should more desire or be permitted to come than can be accommodated at this time other vessels will be sent for them, and in this case I would like to be informed where they will be assembled and the time at which it would be advisable to send. I hope that this effort to relieve the necessities of these poor people, who are in no way responsible for the present unfortunate war, will be met in the spirit it is made.

I am, sir, very respectfully, your obedient servant,

I. N. PALMER,
Brigadier-General, Commanding.

HEADQUARTERS ARMIES OF THE UNITED STATES,

Cold Harbor, Va., June 3, 1864—2 p. m.

(Received 7.55 a. m. 4th.)

Maj. Gen. H. W. HALLECK,

Chief of Staff:

We assaulted at 4.30 o'clock this morning, driving the enemy within his intrenchments at all points, but without gaining any decisive advantage. Our troops now occupy a position close to the enemy, some places within 50 yards, and are intrenching. Our loss was not severe, nor do I suppose the enemy to have lost heavily. We captured over 300 prisoners, mostly from Breckinridge's command.

U. S. GRANT,
Lieutenant-General.

HEADQUARTERS ARMIES OF THE UNITED STATES,

Cold Harbor, Va., June 3, 1864—3 p. m.

(Received 8 a. m. 4th.)

Maj. Gen. H. W. HALLECK,

Chief of Staff:

In view of the time it would take to get orders to New Orleans, and to transport troops from there here, I do not think it advisable to bring the Nineteenth Corps to this field. Since Banks' disaster, too, all the troops in the Trans-Mississippi division may be required there. If there are any surplus troops west they could be advantageously used against Mobile, as suggested in Sherman's dispatch of May 30. Please so order. Let Reynolds or Franklin command the expedition. The sixty pontoon-boats coming from New York with what we have here and at Fort Monroe will be sufficient.

U. S. GRANT,
Lieutenant-General.

HEADQUARTERS SIXTH CORPS,

June 3, 1864. (Received 5.15 a. m.)

Lieutenant-General GRANT:

General Barlow reports that he has enemy's works with colors and guns. I am at General Wright's headquarters.

GEO. G. MEADE,
Major-General.

HEADQUARTERS SIXTH CORPS,

June 3, 1864—5.30 a. m.

Lieutenant-General GRANT :

Hancock reports Barlow could not hold the works carried, but has retired a short distance, and is about attacking again. Colors advancing and near the works. Heavy firing in Smith's front, but no report of progress from either him or Wright.

GEO. G. MEADE,
Major-General.

HEADQUARTERS SIXTH CORPS,

June 3, 1864—6.30 a. m.

Lieutenant-General GRANT :

I send dispatch from Hancock and reply. No reports from Wright and Smith.

GEO. G. MEADE,
Major-General.

[Inclosure No. 1.]

SECOND ARMY CORPS,

June 3, 1864—6 a. m.

General MEADE :

My First and Second Divisions have both been engaged. The men are very close to the enemy, under a crest, but seem unable to carry it. Birney is occupying the advanced line of works vacated by First and Second Divisions in moving to the assault. The commanders of First and Second Divisions do not think they can use more troops than their own with any great certainty of success. I shall await your orders, but express the opinion that if the first dash in an assault fails, other attempts are not apt to succeed better.

WINF'D S. HANCOCK,
Major-General.

[Inclosure No. 2.]

HEADQUARTERS ARMY OF THE POTOMAC,

June 3, 1864—6.35 a. m.

Major-General HANCOCK :

Your dispatch received. You will make the attack and support it well, so that in the event of being successful, the advantage gained can be held. If unsuccessful report at once.

GEO. G. MEADE,
Major-General.

HEADQUARTERS,

June 3, 1864—7 a. m.

Lieutenant-General GRANT :

Reports from Wright announce some progress. His advance occupies a line of the enemy's pits—I presume their skirmish line. He reports the Eighteenth Corps having occupied the same line, but retiring. His (Wright's) line is pushing on. No report from Smith. I sent you one from Hancock, reporting he was about attempting another assault, written before my order to him to do so had reached him. I should be glad to have your views as to the continuance of these attacks, if unsuccessful.

GEO. G. MEADE,
Major-General.

NEAR COLD HARBOR, *June 3, 1864—7 a. m.*

Major-General MEADE,

Commanding Army of the Potomac:

The moment it becomes certain that an assault cannot succeed, suspend the offensive, but when one does succeed push it vigorously, and if necessary pile in troops at the successful point from wherever they can be taken. I shall go to where you are in the course of an hour.

U. S. GRANT,
Lieutenant-General.

COLD HARBOR, *June 3, 1864—12.30 p. m.*

Major-General MEADE,

Commanding Army of the Potomac:

The opinion of corps commanders not being sanguine of success in case an assault is ordered, you may direct a suspension of farther advance for the present. Hold our most advanced positions, and strengthen them. Whilst on the defensive, our line may be contracted from the right, if practicable. Reconnaissances should be made in front of every corps, and advances made to advantageous positions by regular approaches. To aid the expedition under General Hunter it is necessary that we should detain all the army now with Lee until the former gets well on his way to Lynchburg. To do this effectually it will be better to keep the enemy out of the intrenchments of Richmond than to have them go back there. Wright and Hancock should be ready to assault in case the enemy should break through General Smith's lines, and all should be ready to resist an assault.

U. S. GRANT,
Lieutenant-General.

HEADQUARTERS ARMY OF THE POTOMAC,

June 3, 1864—5.45 p. m.

Lieut. Gen. U. S. GRANT,

Commanding:

GENERAL: The telegrams you return were sent from here by me, so that you need not return them. Warren was re-enforced by Birney, and posted him on his left, where he now is, forming connection between Smith and Warren. I have notified Warren there are no other troops to send him, and that he and Burnside must contract their lines to-night. Everything is apparently quiet along the lines. We hold all our advanced positions, and are intrenching. To-night Hancock will establish batteries, and we will begin all along the lines, digging up to the enemy's works. I have sent out officers to each of the corps and to the hospitals to endeavor to form some estimate of the casualties to-day.

Respectfully,

GEO. G. MEADE,
Major-General, Commanding.

COLD HARBOR, VA., *June 5, 1864.*

General R. E. LEE,

Commanding Confederate Army:

It is reported to me that there are wounded men, probably of both armies, now lying exposed and suffering between the lines occupied respectively by the two armies. Humanity would dictate that some provision should be made to provide against such hardships. I would propose, therefore, that hereafter when no battle is raging either party be authorized to send to any point between the pickets or skirmish lines, unarmed men bearing litters to pick up their dead or wounded without being fired upon by the other party. Any other method equally fair to both parties you may propose for meeting the end desired, will be accepted by me.

U. S. GRANT,
Lieutenant-General.

HEADQUARTERS ARMY OF NORTHERN VIRGINIA.

June 5, 1864.

Lieut. Gen. U. S. GRANT,

Commanding U. S. Armies:

GENERAL: I have the honor to acknowledge the receipt of your letter of this date proposing that hereafter, except in time of action, either party be at liberty to remove the dead and wounded from between the lines. I fear that such an arrangement will lead to misunderstanding and difficulty. I propose, therefore, instead, that when either party desires to remove their dead or wounded, a flag of truce be sent, as is customary. It will always afford me pleasure to comply with such a request as far as circumstances will permit.

Very respectfully, your obedient servant,

R. E. LEE,
General.

SPECIAL ORDERS, } HDQRS. ARMIES OF THE UNITED STATES,

No. 28. } *Cold Harbor, Va., June 5, 1864.*

1. Brig. Gen. J. G. Barnard, U. S. Volunteers, having reported for duty to the lieutenant-general commanding, is hereby announced as chief engineer of the armies in the field, and will be respected and obeyed accordingly.

* * * * *

By command of Lieutenant-General Grant:

E. S. PARKER,
Assistant Adjutant-General.

HEADQUARTERS ARMY OF THE POTOMAC,

OFFICE CHIEF QUARTERMASTER,

Camp near Cold Harbor, June 5, 1864.

Brig. Gen. S. WILLIAMS,

Adjutant-General, Army of the Potomac:

GENERAL: I have the honor to report, for the information of the major-general commanding, that the White House depot is fully established and in most efficient operation. All needful supplies of

ORDERS.]

HEADQUARTERS ARMY OF THE POTOMAC,

June 5, 1864—4 p. m.

The following movements and changes are ordered for to-night, and will commence as soon after dark as practicable:

1. Major-General Warren will withdraw and move by way of Old Church to the vicinity of Leary's, about 2 miles in rear of Cold Harbor, where he will remain in reserve, prepared to move wherever required.

2. Major-General Burnside will change his position, keeping his left united with General Smith's right, in the best manner the ground admits of, and extend along Roundabout Creek and the Matadequin, past Allen's Mill, toward the fork of Old Church road, near the crossing of the Matadequin.

3. Major-General Smith will modify his right in the manner required by this change of position of General Burnside.

4. Brigadier-General Ferrero will hold his command ready to move on the morning of the 6th.

5. Major-General Hancock will extend his picket or skirmish line, with strong supports, to the nearest point of the Chickahominy, relieving the cavalry pickets in that space.

6. Major-General Sheridan will hold two divisions of his cavalry ready to carry out, at the time to be indicated, the special instructions which will be given him. A brigade of the remaining division will be posted at Old Church, and picket from the right of General Burnside to the Pamunkey. The other brigade will picket the Chickahominy from the left of General Hancock. The changes in the position of the cavalry will be made at such time and by such routes as not to interfere with the movements of the infantry.

By command of Major-General Meade:

S. WILLIAMS,
Assistant Adjutant-General.

SECOND CORPS,
June 5, 1864—7.45 a. m.

General WILLIAMS:

I shall have a detailed report of operations last night at 8 o'clock. My information now is that the two advanced points in front of General Gibbon and General Barlow are partially connected by a rifle-pit, which will be about 300 yards long when completed, and some 15 or 20 yards nearer the enemy than the one now held.

WINF'D S. HANCOCK,
Major-General.

SECOND CORPS,
June 5, 1864—1 p. m.

General WILLIAMS:

Can any arrangement be made by which the wounded in front of Barlow can be removed? I understand men wounded on the 3d are still lying there.

WINF'D S. HANCOCK,
Major-General, Commanding.

[First indorsement.]

Respectfully referred to Lieutenant-General Grant.

Is it possible to ask, under flag of truce, for permission to remove the wounded now lying between our lines, and which the enemy's sharpshooters prevent me bringing off?

The wounded are lying in front of the Second, Sixth, and Eighteenth Corps.

Respectfully,

GEO. G. MEADE,
Major-General.

[Second indorsement.]

A flag might be sent proposing to suspend firing where the wounded are, until each party get their own. I have no objection to such a course.*

U. S. GRANT,
Lieutenant-General.

SECOND CORPS,
June 5, 1864—1.15 p. m.

General GEORGE G. MEADE,
Commanding Army of the Potomac:

GENERAL: We picket along the Dispatch road, beyond the point where the enemy hold it to the Mechanicsville road, where we connect with the cavalry pickets. Have you any orders for Birney other than your verbal ones to me? The enemy are extending to the left and building works. I ought to leave one brigade of Birney's in reserve to form in part a second line for Gibbon.

Your obedient servant,

WINF'D S. HANCOCK,
Major-General.

HEADQUARTERS SECOND ARMY CORPS,
June 5, 1864—1.30 p. m.

Brig. Gen. JOHN GIBBON,
Commanding Second Division, Second Corps:

GENERAL: General Meade informed me this morning that he had been told that night before last, when the enemy assaulted your line of Smyth and Owen, the enemy took your front line and that our artillery drove them out. As I had heard of no such thing I denied it, but I desire to hear from you on the subject.

Your obedient servant,

WINF'D S. HANCOCK,
Major-General, Commanding.

[First indorsement.]

HEADQUARTERS SECOND DIVISION,
June 5, 1864.

This communication is respectfully referred to Brigadier-General Owen and Colonel Smyth, commanding Second and Third Brigades, who will please make statements of the facts in the case.

JOHN GIBBON,
Brigadier-General of Volunteers, Comdg. Division.

* See Meade to Grant, 1.30 p. m., p. 599.

torious and capable chief engineer of the Army of the Potomac, Major Duane. I noticed the great value of Coehorn mortars in the trenches of this position. Whether needed here or not, similar circumstances may arise elsewhere, and I mention them under the impression that if needed the Ordnance Department may not be able to furnish them at short notice. In view of possible siege operations it would be well to collect a siege train at Fort Monroe.

I am, very respectfully, your most obedient servant,

J. G. BARNARD,

Chief Engineer Armies in the Field.

COLD HARBOR, VA., June 6, 1864.

General R. E. LEE,

Commanding Army of Northern Virginia:

Your communication of yesterday's date is received. I will send immediately, as you propose, to collect the dead and wounded between the lines of the two armies, and will also instruct that you be allowed to do the same. I propose that the time for doing this be between the hours of 12 m. and 3 p. m. to-day. I will direct all parties going out to bear a white flag, and not to attempt to go beyond where we have dead or wounded, and not beyond or on ground occupied by your troops.

U. S. GRANT,

Lieutenant-General.

HEADQUARTERS ARMY OF NORTHERN VIRGINIA,

June 6, 1864.

Lieut. Gen. U. S. GRANT,

Commanding U. S. Army:

GENERAL: I have the honor to acknowledge the receipt of your letter of this date and regret to find that I did not make myself understood in my communication of yesterday. I intended to say that I could not consent to the burial of the dead and the removal of the wounded between the armies in the way you propose, but that when either party desire such permission it shall be asked for by flag of truce in the usual way.

Until I receive a proposition from you on the subject to which I can accede with propriety, I have directed any parties you may send under white flags as mentioned in your letter to be turned back.

Very respectfully, your obedient servant,

R. E. LEE,

General.

COLD HARBOR, VA., June 6, 1864.

General R. E. LEE,

Commanding Army of Northern Virginia:

The knowledge that wounded men are now suffering from want of attention, between the two armies, compels me to ask a suspension of hostilities for sufficient time to collect them in, say two hours. Permit me to say that the hours you may fix upon for this will be

agreeable to me, and the same privilege will be extended to such parties as you may wish to send out on the same duty, without further application.

U. S. GRANT,
Lieutenant-General.

HEADQUARTERS ARMY OF NORTHERN VIRGINIA,

June 6, 1864—7 p. m.

Lieut. Gen. U. S. GRANT, *Commanding U. S. Armies:*

GENERAL: I regret that your letter of this date asking a suspension of hostilities to enable you to remove your wounded from between the two armies was received at so late an hour as to make it impossible to give the necessary directions so as to enable you to effect your purpose by daylight.

In order that the suffering of the wounded may not be further protracted, I have ordered that any parties you may send out for the purpose between the hours of 8 and 10 p. m. to-day shall not be molested, and will avail myself of the privilege extended to those from this army to collect any of its wounded that may remain upon the field.

I will direct our skirmishers to be drawn close to our lines between the hours indicated, with the understanding that at the expiration of the time they be allowed to resume their positions without molestation, and that during the interval all military movements be suspended.

Very respectfully, your obedient servant,

R. E. LEE,
General.

HEADQUARTERS ARMY OF THE POTOMAC,

June 6, 1864. (Received 7 a. m. 7th.)

Capt. B. F. FISHER,

Chief Signal Officer, Army of the Potomac:

SIR: I have the honor to submit the following report:

Apparently no change in enemy's position opposite Bottom's Bridge. A small earth-work has been erected since last evening on the Garthright plantation, about 600 yards west of the river. This work can be seen from Savage's farm on east side of the river. There are no guns in it. The floor of the railroad bridge over the Chickahominy with the track upon it is in good order. On the railroad, about 250 yards south of the bridge, the enemy have in position on the track a movable iron-clad battery, with one port-hole in it. This battery presents the appearance of being a burden car having at one end a shield of iron plating sloping upward from the ground sufficiently high to protect the smoke stack of a locomotive, which is in the rear, and extending in width 3 or 4 feet each side of the track. Steam has been kept up in the engine all day. The range of this battery covers the railroad bridge and the track for the distance of half a mile. To our left of this battery are two earth-works, in one of which a gun can be seen. These works have the range of the railroad bridge and track for half a mile.

Very respectfully, your obedient servant,

W. H. HILL,
Captain, Signal Corps, U. S. Army.

Memorandum of troops forwarded from Department of Washington to Army of the Potomac since May 1, 1864—Continued.

Regiment.	Strength.	Regiment.	Strength.
Detachment 184th Pennsylvania.....	70	Company 60th Ohio Volunteer Infantry	76
Battalion, Rendezvous of Distribution.	800	Rendezvous of Distribution and recruits.	1,243
Rendezvous of Distribution.....	297	Battalion Minnesota Volunteers.....	176
187th Pennsylvania Volunteers.....	990	Provisional battalion.....	867
3d Delaware and 94th New York.....	1,150	23d U. S. Colored Troops.....	45
4th Delaware, 5th New York, and 157th Pennsylvania.	1,050	138th Ohio National Guard.....	840
21st Pennsylvania Cavalry (dismounted).	1,038	140th Ohio National Guard.....	800
Company recruits 16th Michigan.....	83	Provisional battalion, Rendezvous of Distribution.	696
2d Pennsylvania Heavy Artillery.....	1,233	Provisional battalion from Briggs.....	448
10th New York Heavy Artillery.....	1,759	155th Ohio National Guard.....	900
Purnell (Maryland) Legion.....	153	179th New York.....	85
1st Delaware Cavalry.....	529	134th Ohio National Guard.....	800
28th, 29th, 31st Colored.....	1,154	5th New Hampshire Volunteers.....	467
37th and 38th Wisconsin.....	830		
179th New York.....	357		48,265
132d Ohio Volunteer Infantry.....	829		

Note in Letter Book, Headquarters Armies of the United States.

This last letter of General Lee* was not delivered at the outposts of General Hancock until after 10 o'clock, the hour fixed by General Lee for the expiration of the armistice. Notwithstanding, the rebel pickets were drawn in as proposed, and a burial party sent out shortly after 8 o'clock, but as our pickets had received no instructions on the subject, the party was captured. On the report of these facts, General Grant has just sent the subjoined letter to the rebel commander.

COLD HARBOR, VA., June 7, 1864—10.30 a. m.

General R. E. LEE, *Comdg. Army of Northern Virginia* :

I regret that your note of 7 p. m. yesterday should have been received at the nearest corps headquarters to where it was delivered after the hour that had been given for the removal of the dead and wounded had expired. 10.45 p. m. was the hour at which it was received at corps headquarters, and between 11 and 12 it reached my headquarters. As a consequence, it was not understood by the troops of this army that there was a cessation of hostilities for the purpose of collecting the dead and wounded, and none were collected. Two officers and six men of the Eighth and Twenty-fifth North Carolina Regiments, who were out in search of the bodies of officers of their respective regiments, were captured and brought into our lines owing to this want of understanding. I regret this, but will state that as soon as I learned the fact I directed that they should not be held as prisoners, but must be returned to their commands. These officers and men having been carelessly brought through our lines to the rear, I have not determined whether they will be sent back the way they came or whether they will be sent by some other route.

Regretting that all my efforts for alleviating the sufferings of wounded men left upon the battle-field have been rendered nugatory,

I remain, &c.,

U. S. GRANT,
Lieutenant-General.

* See June 6, 7 p. m., p. 639.

HEADQUARTERS ARMY OF NORTHERN VIRGINIA,

June 7, 1864—2 p. m.

Lieut. Gen. U. S. GRANT,
Commanding U. S. Armies:

GENERAL: Your note of 10.30 a. m. to-day has just been received. I regret that my letter to you of 7 p. m. yesterday should have been too late in reaching you to effect the removal of the wounded.

I am willing, if you desire it, to devote the hours between 6 and 8 this afternoon to accomplish that object upon the same terms and conditions as set forth in my letter of 7 p. m. yesterday. If this will answer your purpose, and you will send parties from your lines at the hour designated with white flags, I will direct that they be recognized and be permitted to collect the dead and wounded.

I will also notify the officers on my lines that they will be permitted to collect any of our men that may be on the field. I request you will notify me as soon as practicable if this arrangement is agreeable to you. Lieutenant McAllister, Corporal Martin, and two privates of the Eighth North Carolina Regiment, and Lieutenant Hartman, Corpl. T. Kinlow, and Privates Bass and Grey were sent last night, between the hours of 8 and 10 p. m., for the purpose of recovering the body of Colonel Murchison, and as they have not returned, I presume they are the men mentioned in your letter. I request that they be returned to our lines.

Very respectfully, your obedient servant,

R. E. LEE,
General.

[Indorsement.]

JUNE 7, 1864.

Referred to General G. G. Meade, commanding Army of the Potomac.

I will notify General Lee that hostilities will cease from 6 to 8 for the purposes mentioned. You may send the officers and men referred to as you deem best. Please return this.

U. S. GRANT,
Lieutenant-General.

COLD HARBOR, VA., June 7, 1864—5.30 p. m.

General R. E. LEE,

Commanding Army of Northern Virginia:

Your note of this date just received. It will be impossible for me to communicate the fact of the truce by the hour named by you (6 p. m.), but I will avail myself of your offer at the earliest possible moment, which I hope will not be much after that hour. The officers and men taken last evening are the same mentioned in your note and will be returned.

U. S. GRANT,
Lieutenant-General.

HDQRS. ARMY OF THE POTOMAC, SIGNAL DEPARTMENT,

June 7, 1864.

Maj. Gen. A. A. HUMPHREYS,
Chief of Staff:

GENERAL: I have the honor to report the following batteries, &c., of the enemy upon the south side of the Chickahominy: Opposite